Guidance for Emergency Management of Adult Patients with low body weight and/or of short stature

On occasion, adults with low body weight, including patients of short stature, are admitted to Nebraska Medicine. Their admission can sometimes create uncertainty regarding appropriate emergency management. The following guidance is intended to clarify expectations and promote safe, consistent care.

Definition of low body weight and/or short stature

For the purposes of emergency response at NM, an adult patient of 40 kg or less is considered to be of low body weight. Patients of short stature fall in the lowest 3rd percentile or 2 standard deviations below the mean. Frequently defined as less than 5'3" for men and 4'11" for women.

Medication Dosing

These patients have adult physiology and organ function.
Therefore, medications required during emergency response should be dosed according to standard adult guidelines, not weight-based formulas, unless specifically directed otherwise by the attending provider.

Equipment Considerations

Adult patients with low body weight and/or short stature may have underlying cardiorespiratory or airway abnormalities, so responders should anticipate possible need for advanced airway support, such as video or fiberoptic laryngoscopy.

Use of a pediatric crash cart is not recommended, as it increases the risk of error due to unfamiliarity with the cart setup in adult care environments. The adult code cart contains all necessary equipment appropriate to care for adult patients with low body weight and/or short stature except for the possible need for advanced airway equipment as noted above.

Recommendation

In the event of an emergency, adult patients with low body weight and/or short stature should be medically managed as adult patients, *unless* a physician on the primary team gives alternate instructions based on the patient's specific clinical needs.